

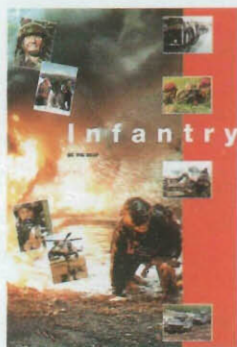
ARMIES



FROM ANCIENT TIMES to the present day, the role of an army has always remained the same – to attack enemy territory and defend the country from attack. Armies usually work in close partnership with air and naval forces. Throughout history, foot soldiers called infantry have done most of the fighting, supported by troops on horseback called cavalry. Today, cavalry have been replaced on the battlefield by armoured tank units.

Modern army

Combat troops fighting in the front line need plenty of support. Engineers, for example, repair damaged roads and bridges to help troops cross rough terrain. Other support staff includes doctors and nurses to treat wounded soldiers, caterers to feed the army, and communications experts.



Recruitment

In some countries, the army is made up entirely of volunteer recruits who willingly join the army for a fixed period of time. In other countries, the army is made up largely of conscripts – that is, young people required by law to spend a number of years in the army.

British Army recruitment poster

Training

Modern weapons use advanced technology, so troops need to be not just physically fit but also able to make split-second decisions and operate highly complex computerized equipment. For this reason, technical instruction is just as important a part of a soldier's training as exercise and parade-ground drill.



Terrorist armies

Sometimes, armies are set up by groups of people struggling to overthrow the existing government or achieve independence for their country or region. Their supporters call them freedom fighters, but those who oppose them call them terrorists. Such groups often stage spectacular bomb attacks to gain publicity for their cause.

Terrorist bomb damage



Non-combat roles

When a nation is at peace, its army still has a vital role to play. For example, when natural disasters occur – such as earthquakes, floods, or famines – an army can bring in medical supplies and food, and restore communications links and electricity and water supplies. Armies can also help to establish peace in other war-torn countries.



Peacekeeping

To separate warring sides in a civil war or to keep the peace once a ceasefire has been negotiated, the United Nations (UN) often sends multinational forces consisting of troops from many different armies.



Crisis response

Armies need to react quickly and efficiently in times of crisis. Huge cargo aircraft carry supplies, trucks, and even small tanks to the crisis area, while passenger planes take troops and other personnel.



Ancient Greece

Each Greek city-state had its own army. Greek soldiers were so well regarded that other countries hired them to fight on their behalf.

History of armies

The world's first armies, raised in Assyria, Egypt, China, and India, were ill-trained, undisciplined civilians forced to fight for their leaders. The ancient Greeks introduced compulsory military service and rigorous training for their civilian army. Later, the Romans established the first professional (paid) army to protect its empire.



SAS survival kit

Specialist units

Most armies have units of troops trained to carry out specialist tasks, such as reconnaissance missions and sabotage raids behind enemy lines, tackling terrorists, and rescuing hostages. These units include the US Army's Green Berets and the British Special Air Service (SAS).

British officer's shoulder strap

Italian officer's cap badge

Officers

An army needs a strong chain of command, from the highest to the lowest ranks, so that orders are passed on quickly and clearly. Officers receive training in leading and inspiring their troops. Officers' ranks are shown by special symbols on their uniforms.